Call the cops: advice from friends and family in victim crime reporting

S. Bondarkov[a]

[a]The Institute for the Rule of Law at the European University at Saint-Petersburg, 6/1 A Gagarinskaya Street, St. Petersburg, Russia

ARTICLE HISTORY
Compiled December 25, 2025

ABSTRACT
TBA

KEYWORDS
Victimization; reporting crime; social support

1. Introduction

Suppose a rock smashes your window — wrapped around it is a note saying: 'You are the gatekeeper of criminal justice system now (Gottfredson & Gottfredson, 1987)'. That must be confusing. To make sense of what just happened and to figure out a course of action you may want to relate the experience to someone. In the end of this conversation you may choose to mobilize the law by notifiyng the police (D. J. Black, 1973) or to follow the code of the street (Anderson, 1999) and personally confront the frustrated editor that you suspect could not tolerate another opening "gatekeeper" citation in a paper on victim reporting behavior.

Victimization is not a light subject, of course, neither are help-seeking or under-reporting of crime. The imaginary scenario above is intended not to ridicule, but to fast-forward us past the stage where I am ritually convincing you in precisely that (that is, in the well established understanding that these are serious problems worth consideration – which, let's face it, reader, we already share) – and to simultaneously give you the idea of a behavior mechanism that is at the center of this research.

I assume that, since any victimization is known to be unexpected and cause stress and confusion, if for entirely different reasons, we should expect that a victim of a real crime would also turn to others in order "to reduce their uncertainty and be reassured" (Ruback, Greenberg, & Westcott, 1984). I argue that, other things being equal, in certain types of crime victimization this decision to seek help in others is the most important factor of reporting the incident to the police. While often overlooked, the importance of social support in victim crime reporting is not unrecognized, as I will show in the next section. However, historically most of the work on the subject was focused on sexualized and intimate partner violence (IPV), evidence for other types

CONTACT S. Bondarkov. Email: sbondarkov@eu.spb.ru

of crime remaining scarce (Xie & Baumer, 2019) or, as is the case with cybercrime, non-existent. This is the gap that I address in this paper.

I aim to test whether advice from another person, or, more strictly, the opportunity to talk the incident through with someone a victim relies on, significantly influences the probability that the police will be notified. My perspective on the matter is primarily based on the model of victim decision making developed by Greenberg and Ruback (Greenberg & Ruback, 1992; Ruback et al., 1984; **?**): a victim may need help to identify the incident as victimization, in the first place; another person's input – their emotional support, their perspective on gravity of the accident, on available options of response and on possible consequences – must also weigh heavy in the decision making process. At the same time, in the spirit of calls for integrative approach (Pescosolido, 1992; Xie & Baumer, 2019), I attempt to connect social influence model with those suggested in several strains of reporting literature, namely those emphasizing structural factors (D. Black, 1976), situational characteristics and (semi-)rational evaluation of those (Gottfredson & Hindelang, 1979a; Skogan, 1984; Tarling & Morris, 2010), attitudes towards criminal justice (Goudriaan, Lynch, & Nieuwbeerta, 2004), and relational distance between offender and victim (Felson, Messner, & Hoskin, 1999). To this end, I use pooled data from three waves of the Russian Crime Victimization Survey (RCVS) (**?**) – a regular and nationally representative monitoring that targets Russian citizens of 18 years and older.

Traditionally (Gottfredson & Hindelang, 1979a; Skogan, 1976, 1984; Tarling & Morris, 2010), gravity of an incident, i.e. perceived actual and potential harm, is seen as the main predictor of reporting to the police. *TBA: add on other frameworks tested by Arina and Kirill.* Recent research by Dzmitryieva and Titaev (2025) showed that this view is relevant in Russian context, too.

TBA: more findings from Kirill and Arina. More rigorous approach.

TBA: Social support framework / world / IPV / some property evidence However, social support framework, developed mostly in literature on victims of rape and IPV, was left out – which is all the more natural, given that rape and IPV is out of the scope of RCVS. I build on their result assuming that in other types of crime social support factor is still relevant. I also recognize that post-victimization behavior is known to vary with crime type (**?**), so I estimate six separate models on different subsets of data: all violent crime, all property crime, assaults, robberies, thefts, fraud, and, finally, cybercrime.

I find that, after controlling for incident gravity and other possible confounders, the fact of sharing the experience with a confident is the strongest predictor of notifying the police about violent victimization. My modeling suggests that this connection is especially pronounced in cases where the perpetrator is someone close. Turning to property crime, I do not find effect of speaking to others on face-to-face fraud, however, there is a tentative evidence of positive effect of consultation with another person proves on the probability of reporting theft and cybercrime.

My paper contributes to ...

To my knowledge, this is the first paper to analyze reporting of cybercrime in connection with social support ...

A by-product of my work is an analysis of personal covariates of seeking help in intimate circle ...

The rest of the paper is conveniently organized the way you would expect. After the literature review in Section 2, I will introduce my data (Section 3) and analytical approach (Section 4), present my results (Section 5), tackle possible effect identification problems (Subsection 5.1), offer a discussion of findings (Section 6) and conclude with

conclusion (Section 7).

2. Literature review

There are, arguably, three main metaphors that has been shaping research on reporting so far. The first, "purely sociological", is Black's "law as a natural phenomenon" that has its own behavior (D. Black, 1976). The second, coming from economist mindset, depicts victim as a rational subject engaged in cost-benefit calculus. Enjoying a status close to common sense, this image has guided most of the work in the field, and found consistent empirical support. Time after time the gravity of a crime proved to be the most important predictor of reporting (Gottfredson & Hindelang, 1979a; Skogan, 1984; Tarling & Morris, 2010; **?**) which backed the veracity of rational choice model.

Amusingly, the third metaphor, stemming from developmental psychology and seemingly reconciling the macro- and micro- levels, i.e. "nature" and individual, is the metaphor of ecology (Bronfenbrenner, 1979). It has been used explicitly at least since Goudriaan et al. (2004) challenged the by then established domination of cost-benefit perspective, arguing that as a result of it 'we know a great deal about how characteristics of crimes, victims, and the relationship between victims and offenders are related to reporting, but relatively little about contextual effects at the meso- or macrolevel. Specifically, we do not know how norms, resources and policies at the organizational, community, jurisdiction, and nation level influence the decision to report.'[1] Ecological model of reporting did not dethrone the cost-benefit view of victim's decision making. Rather, it provided correction, taking into account environment in which calculus takes place, or, as Pescosolido (1992) put it regarding the revised rational choice perspective on how people seek medical help, it still 'focuses on the individual but tilts the analytic lens upward in an attempt to capture other larger conditions (including networks) that affect the individual unit of analysis'.

TBA: examples of studies employing ecological framework and their findings (Baumer, 2002; Berg & Rogers, 2017; Goudriaan, Wittebrood, & Nieuwbeerta, 2006).

Attitudes literature goes here (dressed as ecological).

While acknowledging the influence others may exert on a victim's decision to call the police, ecological model does not fully recognize the interactive nature of this social act. Yet, indications of such a nature were there right from the start. Two massive studies of police response time (Spelman & Brown, 1985; Van Kirk, 1978) found that most of the time dialing the police was delayed by people talking to others, either witnesses or advisors, in order to gather information, make sense of the situation or cope with stress. This lead Ruback et al. (1984) to suggest a new framework of victim decision making grounded in social psychology and fully developed in their *After the Crime* (Greenberg & Ruback, 1992). At first glance, their model was not unlike the "naming-claiming-blaming" model of disputes emergence (Felstiner, Abel, & Sarat, 1981). It decomposed the process into three stages, too: a) labeling event as a crime, b) determining its seriousness, 3) deciding what to do. Moreover, both models accounted for social influence. The main difference between the two was that, despite nodding to social psychology, the first was ecological in spirit, while the second focused

[1] It is not too desperate to argue that implicitly the understanding of reporting as a multilevel process has been present at least ever since Gottfredson and Hindelang (1979a) tested predictions from Black's theory on the individual-level victimization survey data and the ensuing stand-off (D. Black, 1979; Gottfredson & Hindelang, 1979b): most studies has combined different micro- and meso- level variables, if not articulating it like that.

on psychological mechanisms at work.

At the center of Greenberg and Ruback's framework is, once again, an individual, but one that is fundamentally stressed, confused, their assumptions about the world challenged or shattered (Janoff-Bulman, 1986). Rather than seeking to maximize their net profit, in this perspective a victim acts to ameliorate the distress and to protect their peace of mind in the long run. The part that "counselors" play on each of the three stages is emphasized, more so given that a victim may be in a state of ambiguity or shock which makes them susceptible to influence. This influence can take form of cuing the victim to particular options and scripts not yet considered, providing information, channeling certain norms, offering emotional and practical support.

In a series of experiments and reviews of archival material... However, experiments, clever as they were, had limited generelizability.

In a later work Greenberg and Beach (2004)... Mason and Benson (1996)... However, remains scarce.

Even in literature on reporting of rape the relationship between police reporting of SA and previous contact with support persons received little attention so far in quantitative studies. Baert et al. (2024): *To our knowledge, only one study showed that consulting with an informal support person about whether to report positively increased the likelihood of reporting (Paul et al., 2014), and none examined the association between police reporting of SA and consultation of formal support persons.*

Knoth and Ruback (2019): *Thus, studies that assess differences between individuals who report to the police, seek alternative help, or do nothing (e.g., Kaukinen, 2002) often fail to recognize that individuals who do end up calling the police are likely to first seek advice from a third party.*

Later research recognizing the role of counselors: Kaukinen (2002), Zaykowski (2015), etc.

Most recent work, integrative approach: Xie and Baumer (2019), Bergemann (2024)

3. Data PLACEHOLDER

In this analysis, we used pooled cross-sectional data obtained by merging two waves of the Russian Crime Victimization Surveys, conducted in 2018 and 2021 (Knorre, 2019, 2022). These surveys employed nearly identical questionnaires and shared a consistent methodology, which made their integration analytically sound. This approach increases statistical power and the precision of estimates (Verbeek, 2008), with year fixed effects included in the analysis to control for differences between the survey periods. The surveys were conducted using Computer-Assisted personal communication (CATI) with Random Digit Dialing (RDD) of mobile phone numbers. In this approach, the system generates a random number, invites a call, and if a respondent answers, the operator proceeds with the interview.

The survey achieved a 14.1% completion rate among individuals who answered the phone call. Of the people who answered the phone, 16.5% agreed to answer the interviewer's question, and of those who agreed, 85.5% proceeded to complete the full survey. Although CATI with RDD is not commonly used in victimisation research, this strategy proved more appropriate in the Russian context, where large-scale falsifications by field interviewers in face-to-face surveys are a persistent problem (Rogozin & Ipatova, 2015).

Both surveys implemented a simple random sampling strategy, aiming to interview 3,000 individuals who had experienced victimisation within the past five years. Ad-

ditionally, participants were also asked about their victimisation experiences in the past twelve months. The survey instruments captured data from both victims and non-victims, collecting detailed information on socio-demographic characteristics, income, and experiences with crime. The survey was conducted across all geographical areas of the country, covering approximately 3,500 locations.

Both the RCVS2018 and RCVS2021 surveys achieved a high degree of representativeness at the national level based on key socio-demographic indicators (Serebrennikov & Titaev, 2022; Verkeev et al., 2019). A comparison of the respondents' principal sociodemographic characteristics with data from the Federal State Statistics Service of Russia (GKS, 2019) and the Comprehensive Survey of Living Conditions of the Population (KOUZ, 2020) reveals statistically insignificant differences in age and gender. However, the RCVS sample shows a slight skew in age and education level, with those aged 65 and older underrepresented and individuals with higher education overrepresented. This bias can be attributed to the lower availability of the elderly for personal communication due to health or technological barriers, and the higher availability of educated individuals. As is often the case, marginalised populations are less accessible to survey methodologies, potentially leading to missing data on major violent crimes (Verkeev et al., 2019).

The questionnaires used in RCVS2018 and RCVS2021 were nearly identical. The RCVS2018 questionnaire was developed through in-depth interviews with victims of various crimes and an extensive review of victimisation surveys in other countries (Verkeev et al., 2019). In early 2021, a methodological audit of the RCVS2018 was conducted, leading to minor revisions and the inclusion of new questions. However, these revisions did not affect the variables used in the present analysis. Since not all events reported to the police meet the legal definition of a crime, this study uses the term "incident" to refer to any such reported event, regardless of its legal qualification.

Victims were identified based on their response to the following survey question: "Please recall whether you were robbed, assaulted, threatened, or were a victim of violence, fraud, or other crimes in Russia during the last 5 years?" Respondents who answered affirmatively were classified as victims for this analysis. Table 1 presents descriptive statistics from the two surveys, showing the initial distribution of victims and non-victims. For the purposes of our analysis, only respondents who reported victimisation were included. The data were analysed using the statistical analysis software Stata version 14, and were prepared, cleaned, and captured in the Statistical Package for Social Sciences (SPSS) version 25 prior to analysis.

TBA:

Add on raking procedure.

Table 1 describes the data I use... It is evident that most people do inform someone close about victimization incident and that it is positively correlated with reporting to the police. However, as I show in Section 4, at this point we should rather attribute this to multiple confounders of the two variables...

Table **??** in Appendix documents questions behind the variables and my aggregation decisions...

4. Analytical approach

4.1. Dependent variable

Definition of reporting, definitions of crime types (wording in questionaire).

Table 1. Victimization and reported incidents share tabulated by variables used in this study

		Cybercrime		Fraud		Theft		Assault		Robbery	
		N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)	N	Rep. (SE)
Panel A. Totals											
Wave	2018	474	0.45 (0.02)	351	0.39 (0.03)	905	0.61 (0.02)	229	0.53 (0.03)	150	0.71 (0.04)
	2021	865	0.45 (0.02)	214	0.53 (0.03)	562	0.63 (0.02)	276	0.59 (0.03)	104	0.69 (0.05)
	2024	735	0.51 (0.02)	35	0.73 (0.08)	426	0.59 (0.02)	285	0.56 (0.03)	86	0.6 (0.05)
	Pooled	2074	0.47 (0.01)	600	0.45 (0.02)	1893	0.61 (0.01)	790	0.56 (0.02)	340	0.67 (0.03)
Panel B. Socioeconomic status											
Gender	Female	1129	0.48 (0.01)	294	0.48 (0.03)	938	0.63 (0.02)	299	0.62 (0.03)	129	0.77 (0.04)
	Male	945	0.46 (0.02)	306	0.42 (0.03)	955	0.6 (0.02)	491	0.52 (0.02)	211	0.61 (0.03)
Age	18-24	193	0.33 (0.03)	39	0.49 (0.08)	165	0.37 (0.04)	134	0.35 (0.04)	52	0.41 (0.07)
	25-34	513	0.44 (0.02)	138	0.31 (0.04)	454	0.63 (0.02)	218	0.49 (0.03)	88	0.55 (0.05)
	35-49	756	0.49 (0.02)	195	0.49 (0.04)	654	0.67 (0.02)	282	0.64 (0.03)	119	0.66 (0.04)
	50-64	414	0.48 (0.02)	137	0.55 (0.04)	411	0.56 (0.02)	120	0.7 (0.04)	57	0.86 (0.05)
	65+	198	0.59 (0.04)	91	0.4 (0.05)	207	0.7 (0.03)	36	0.84 (0.06)	23	0.94 (0.05)
Has partner	No	790	0.47 (0.02)	249	0.45 (0.03)	694	0.57 (0.02)	383	0.52 (0.03)	143	0.65 (0.04)
	Yes	1284	0.47 (0.01)	351	0.45 (0.03)	1199	0.64 (0.01)	407	0.6 (0.02)	197	0.69 (0.03)
Settlement type	City	1415	0.48 (0.01)	438	0.45 (0.02)	1291	0.62 (0.01)	536	0.52 (0.02)	235	0.63 (0.03)
	Small town	306	0.45 (0.03)	88	0.46 (0.05)	313	0.6 (0.03)	116	0.59 (0.05)	50	0.84 (0.05)
	Village	303	0.47 (0.03)	57	0.45 (0.07)	227	0.61 (0.03)	111	0.7 (0.04)	48	0.76 (0.06)
	Unknown	50	0.39 (0.07)	17	0.4 (0.12)	62	0.65 (0.06)	27	0.65 (0.09)	7	0.51 (0.21)
Education	School	250	0.49 (0.03)	100	0.31 (0.05)	266	0.55 (0.03)	177	0.5 (0.04)	65	0.65 (0.06)
	Vocational	661	0.47 (0.02)	214	0.5 (0.03)	645	0.62 (0.02)	298	0.57 (0.03)	108	0.69 (0.04)
	Tertiary	1159	0.47 (0.01)	286	0.48 (0.03)	981	0.64 (0.02)	311	0.62 (0.03)	166	0.7 (0.04)
Employment	Unemployed	298	0.5 (0.03)	82	0.69 (0.05)	269	0.53 (0.03)	146	0.62 (0.04)	54	0.61 (0.07)
	Pensioner	352	0.54 (0.03)	151	0.41 (0.04)	362	0.67 (0.02)	80	0.79 (0.05)	44	0.9 (0.05)
	Worker	369	0.43 (0.03)	105	0.39 (0.05)	365	0.55 (0.03)	197	0.51 (0.04)	73	0.63 (0.06)
	Manager	417	0.41 (0.02)	119	0.34 (0.04)	370	0.67 (0.02)	137	0.56 (0.04)	75	0.62 (0.06)
	Employee	451	0.5 (0.02)	94	0.5 (0.05)	348	0.63 (0.03)	119	0.61 (0.05)	51	0.71 (0.06)
	Student	187	0.38 (0.04)	49	0.51 (0.07)	179	0.55 (0.04)	111	0.36 (0.05)	43	0.47 (0.08)
Income level	Low	456	0.54 (0.02)	24	0.86 (0.07)	265	0.61 (0.03)	180	0.58 (0.04)	59	0.71 (0.06)
	Middle	203	0.5 (0.04)	7	0.68 (0.19)	107	0.63 (0.05)	61	0.67 (0.06)	15	0.59 (0.13)
	High	58	0.42 (0.07)	4	0.14 (0.18)	39	0.57 (0.08)	34	0.34 (0.08)	6	0.23 (0.19)
Panel C. Incident characteristics											
Damage: money, thnd rubles	[0,1]	263	0.21 (0.03)	70	0.21 (0.05)	249	0.5 (0.03)	599	0.53 (0.02)	49	0.58 (0.07)
	(1,10]	825	0.36 (0.02)	159	0.27 (0.04)	592	0.5 (0.02)	81	0.63 (0.05)	105	0.64 (0.05)
	(10,50]	523	0.51 (0.02)	145	0.51 (0.04)	647	0.65 (0.02)	53	0.6 (0.07)	111	0.71 (0.04)
	(50,Inf]	463	0.74 (0.02)	226	0.65 (0.03)	405	0.79 (0.02)	57	0.82 (0.05)	75	0.73 (0.05)
Damage: physical	No							137	0.42 (0.04)	42	0.66 (0.07)
	Light							381	0.53 (0.03)	130	0.66 (0.04)
	Heavy							272	0.69 (0.03)	90	0.7 (0.05)
Incident: there was a witness	No	1177	0.45 (0.01)	218	0.4 (0.03)	1050	0.66 (0.01)	299	0.53 (0.03)	156	0.66 (0.04)
	Yes	897	0.5 (0.02)	382	0.48 (0.03)	843	0.56 (0.02)	491	0.58 (0.02)	184	0.69 (0.03)
Incident: offender had a weapon	No							544	0.53 (0.02)	175	0.67 (0.04)
	Yes							246	0.64 (0.03)	89	0.68 (0.05)
Incident: resisted	No/Doubt							220	0.69 (0.03)	101	0.73 (0.04)
	Yes							570	0.51 (0.02)	163	0.63 (0.04)
Panel D. Social factors											
Offender-victim relationship	Stranger	1047	0.5 (0.02)	409	0.43 (0.02)	56	0.5 (0.07)	450	0.51 (0.02)	189	0.62 (0.04)
	Acquaintance	38	0.68 (0.08)	75	0.51 (0.06)	12	0.64 (0.14)	84	0.53 (0.05)	32	0.65 (0.09)
	Colleague	12	0.81 (0.12)	59	0.34 (0.06)	4	0.6 (0.29)	18	0.89 (0.08)	9	0.58 (0.18)
	Neighbor	4	0.85 (0.19)	13	0.88 (0.1)	3	0.69 (0.33)	61	0.91 (0.04)	15	1 (0)
	Friend or relative	13	0.62 (0.14)	35	0.67 (0.08)	3	0.51 (0.35)	59	0.57 (0.06)	16	0.93 (0.07)
	Spouse or partner	5	0.55 (0.25)	2	0.71 (0.45)	2	0 (0)	50	0.57 (0.07)	20	0.83 (0.09)
Victim informed friends or relatives	No	321	0.37 (0.03)	62	0.28 (0.06)	137	0.46 (0.04)	144	0.21 (0.03)	46	0.45 (0.07)
	Yes	1753	0.49 (0.01)	538	0.47 (0.02)	1756	0.63 (0.01)	646	0.65 (0.02)	294	0.71 (0.03)
Panel E. Attitude towards police											
Knows a police	No	1044	0.49 (0.02)	306	0.46 (0.03)	918	0.62 (0.02)	349	0.57 (0.03)	168	0.68 (0.04)
	Yes	1026	0.45 (0.02)	294	0.45 (0.03)	975	0.6 (0.02)	439	0.56 (0.02)	170	0.69 (0.04)
Has crime record	No	1914	0.47 (0.01)	550	0.45 (0.02)	1751	0.61 (0.01)	646	0.57 (0.02)	266	0.67 (0.03)
	Yes	159	0.46 (0.04)	50	0.47 (0.07)	141	0.67 (0.04)	142	0.52 (0.04)	73	0.73 (0.05)

Proportions of reported victimizations and standard errors were calculated with weights obtained in raking procedure.

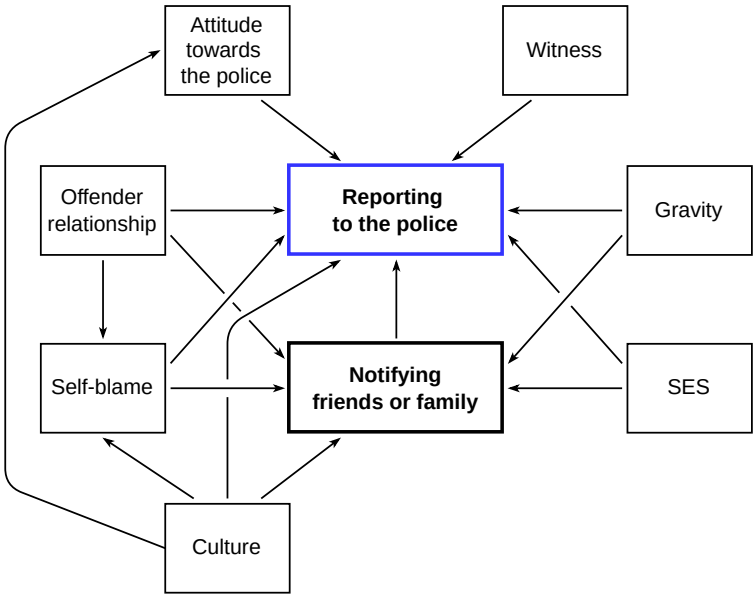


Figure 1. Causal diagram of decision making model

Recency problem (Goudriaan et al., 2004)): *The use of a 5-year reference period has probably resulted in an underestimate of victimization rates and an overestimate of the proportion reported to the police. Memory decays with time and the longer the reference period, the less complete the recall and reporting of crime events. Because events reported to the police are rehearsed and have consequences subsequent to the event, they will be remembered more frequently than events that are not reported to the police. Biderman and Lynch (1981) have shown, however, that this type of recency bias is not correlated with other attributes of the crime, so it is unlikely to affect the analyses presented here. They compared attributes of events reported in the most recent month of the reference period for the National Crime Survey with those reported in the most distant month of the reference period. The distributions of these event attributes were similar for the most proximate and the most distant month of the reference period for all attributes except reporting to the police. The percent reported to the police in the most distant month was significantly greater than the proportion reported to the police in the most proximate month.*

4.2. Independent variables

I regard these variables as possible predictors rather than factors of reporting (Wikström, 2011)...

Incident chars: witness: presence of a witness removes effect of victim-offender relationship FOR THIRD PARTY in study by Felson et al. (1999)...

Goudriaan et al. (2004) juxtapose rational cost-benefit calculus and "normative response": *In contrast, normative responses are not directly caused by expected costs or benefits, but by norms that exist in the victim's social context. "Crimes should be reported to the police," "this is not a case for the police," or "I should deal with this myself' are examples of possible norms that may influence crime reporting.*. This seems a highly doubtful analysis.

A visual summary of causal relations in my model provided in Fig 1 makes it evident

that an integrative framework is not merely reasonable or theoretically sound but plain necessary if one aims to identify the effect of social support on reporting. Almost all the factors that are supposed to influence the decision to notify the police may as well influence the decision to seek help in friends and family. In other words, the dependent and the focus independent variables have multiple confounders. This poses a threat to identification, which I am able to overcome by inclusion of a broad range of controls. However, there are three caveats.

First, I do not observe a victim's cultural context. The only way I am able to try to control for it is to introduce federal district fixed effects and settlement type variable, which is better than nothing but admittedly a very crude solution, because context may vary greatly across a city, not to mention a federal district (Baumer, 2002; Goudriaan et al., 2006).

Second, I do not observe offenders characteristics other than their gender and relation to a victim. I do not include offender gender or interaction of victim-offender genders in my modeling because in my data almost the crime was committed by men. I do include relationship distance which proves to be an important factor. Still, I know nothing of offender's resourcefulness which must be one of the serious considerations in a victim's decision making process. This is an important omission, but one that my study shares with virtually all the research on reporting. *TBAa: fear of reprisal (Felson et al., 1999)*

Third, I know only if the police was notified and if a victim told about the incident to someone in their intimate circle – and I do not know which came first. This means endogeneity is possible: a victim may report to the police and then relate the whole story to friends or family *because* of how the interaction with the police has worked out. While our knowledge of post-victimization behavior suggests that if someone is notified at all then friends or family come before the police (Knoth & Ruback, 2019; Ruback & Thompson, 2001), the doubt remains. I address this issue in Subsection 5.1 by introducing a supporting model of different design.

Motivation for year fixed effects: *Some scholars have attributed substantive meanings to this change and argued that it was caused by changes in sex-role attitudes in the United States (e.g., Orcutt & Faison 1988) or by the success of rape law reforms and media campaigns (e.g., Bachman 1993, Spohn & Horney 1992). The evidence from the United Kingdom similarly supported the notion that research and policy attention to rape, sexual assault, and domestic violence had led to more adequate handling of such crimes and that this had resulted in a greater willingness of victims to report crimes by intimate friends and relatives (Tarling & Morris 2010).*

My main model is logistic regression of the following specification:

$$P(Reported_i) = g(\beta_1 ToldSomeone_i + \beta_2 Relationship_i + \beta_x SES_i + \beta_y Incident_i + \beta_z Attitude_i + \lambda + \gamma) \quad (1)$$

where $g(.)$ is logit function, $ToldSomeone$ is an indicator of informing friends or relative, SES is a vector of socioeconomic status variables, $Incident$ – a vector of situational characteristics, $Attitude$ – a vector of variables that capture a victim's attitude towards police, λ and γ are federal district and year fixed effects.

I run this model on six subsets of victim only data split by crime type: theft, face-to-face fraud, cybercrime, all property crime, assault, all violent crime.

5. Results

Regression results in Table 2 offer both expected and unexpected findings...

We observe effect where victimization is more challenging to a person's assumptions about the world (Janoff-Bulman, 1986).

It may be more instructive to assess predictions from the model in Fig 2: ...

Table 2. Logistic regression result

	Theft	Fraud	Cybercrime	All property	Assault	All violent
Told someone	0.811+	1.005	0.769	0.744+	2.100*	2.152*
Financial: (1, 10] thnd rub.	0.138	0.612	0.929	0.440+	0.859	0.641
Financial: (10, 50] thnd rub.	0.852	1.645+	1.578	1.144*	0.183	0.388
Financial: (50, Inf] thnd rub.	1.477*	2.178+	2.626*	1.889*	1.055+	1.229+
Physical: Light					0.286	0.424
Physical: Heavy					1.162	1.129
Incident: Witness					0.373	0.276
Incident: Victim resisted					-0.422	-0.419
Incident: Weapon					0.323	0.256
Self-blame	-0.620*	-0.163	-0.614+	-0.612*	-0.040	-0.285
Has partner	0.098	-0.279	-0.031	-0.027	0.096	-0.003
Off. rel.: Acquaintance or colleague					0.588	0.342
Off. rel.: Neighbour					1.213	1.396
Off. rel.: Spouse, partner, relative, friend					-0.114	0.099
Gender: Male	-0.309	-0.229	-0.133	-0.195+	-0.458	-0.416
Income: Can buy furniture/electonics	-0.015	0.273	0.170	0.113	0.085	-0.002
Income: Can buy a car, or higher	0.203	0.350	-0.435+	-0.053	0.018	0.019
Highly educated	0.104	-0.031	-0.038	0.016	0.183	0.155
Settlement: Small town	-0.175	0.408	-0.116	-0.050	0.974	1.040
Settlement: Village	-0.123	-0.281	-0.096	-0.108	0.476	0.429
Settlement: Unknown	0.076	0.104	0.116	-0.121	0.665	0.616
Attitude: Victim knows a police	-0.058	-0.227	-0.202	-0.114	-0.028	0.142
Attitude: Victim has crime record	0.511	0.535	-0.267	0.115	-0.198	0.011
Num.Obs.	1834	585	2011	4431	685	883
R2	0.152	0.223	0.166	0.139	0.308	0.291
R2 Adj.	0.125	0.158	0.143	0.128	0.222	0.222
R2 Within	0.105	0.139	0.134	0.104	0.263	0.248
R2 Within Adj.	0.087	0.092	0.119	0.097	0.198	0.196
RMSE	0.45	0.46	0.46	0.46	0.43	0.43
Std.Errors clustered by federal district and year	X	X	X	X	X	X
FE: federal_district	X	X	X	X	X	X
FE: year	X	X	X	X	X	X

+ p ¡ 0.1, * p ¡ 0.05, ** p ¡ 0.01, *** p ¡ 0.001

5.1. Robustness checks

change overtime: Orcutt and Faison (1988); Ruback (1993)

Addressing possible

(1) endogeneity:
- failed IV (only a mention, regression result not included)
- subset of crime with close offenders (Felson et al., 1999)

(2) omitted variables: emotional damage, trust in police (Goudriaan et al., 2004)
- regression on 2024 data with inclusion omitted vars

(3) memory bias:
- switching to sample of those victimized in last 12 months

Table 3. Logistic regression result after controlling for police trust and emotional damage, 2024 data only

	Theft	Cybercrime	All property	Assault	All violent
Told someone	0.045	0.539+	0.486	2.569**	2.510**
Financial: (1, 10] thnd rub.	-0.039	0.700	0.397	0.910	0.752
Financial: (10, 50] thnd rub.	0.871+	1.209**	0.990**	0.298	0.749
Financial: (50, Inf] thnd rub.	1.363**	2.193***	1.770***	0.786	0.972+
Physical: Light				-0.142	-0.104
Physical: Heavy				0.934	0.905
Emotional: Medium	0.870+	0.072	0.247	-1.084	-0.982
Emotional: Heavy	1.252*	0.816*	0.893**	-0.207	0.052
Incident: Witness				0.747	0.645+
Incident: Victim resisted				-0.531	-0.918*
Incident: Weapon				0.673	0.431
Self-blame	-0.395	-0.399	-0.477*	-0.405	-0.532
Has partner	-0.089	-0.073	-0.055	0.073	0.125
Off. rel.: Acquaintance or colleague				1.612*	1.575*
Off. rel.: Neighbour				1.956*	1.919**
Off. rel.: Spouse, partner, relative, friend				0.321	0.546
Gender: Male	0.084	0.137	0.080	-0.412	-0.332
Income: Can buy furniture/electonics	-0.115	0.073	0.005	0.733	0.708+
Income: Can buy a car, or higher	-0.526	-0.311	-0.452	-0.139	-0.143
Highly educated	0.810*	0.333*	0.389**	0.061	-0.008
Settlement: Small town	0.236	-0.289	-0.161	0.586	0.415
Settlement: Village	-0.159	-0.096	-0.250	0.556	0.258
Settlement: Unknown	1.628	-0.697	0.088	0.555	0.415
Attitude: Victim trusts the police	0.307	0.336	0.310	-0.065	0.127
Attitude: Victim knows a police	-0.212	-0.195	-0.180	0.270	0.429
Attitude: Victim has crime record	0.339	0.077	0.247	0.494	0.536
Num.Obs.	405	703	1143	260	304
R2	0.094	0.076	0.058	0.251	0.254
R2 Adj.	-0.030	0.005	0.015	0.010	0.045
R2 Within	0.135	0.136	0.120	0.264	0.272
R2 Within Adj.	0.052	0.090	0.092	0.086	0.117
RMSE	0.44	0.45	0.45	0.41	0.41
Std.Errors clustered by federal district	X	X	X	X	X
FE: federal_district	X	X	X	X	X

+ p ¡ 0.1, * p ¡ 0.05, ** p ¡ 0.01, *** p ¡ 0.001

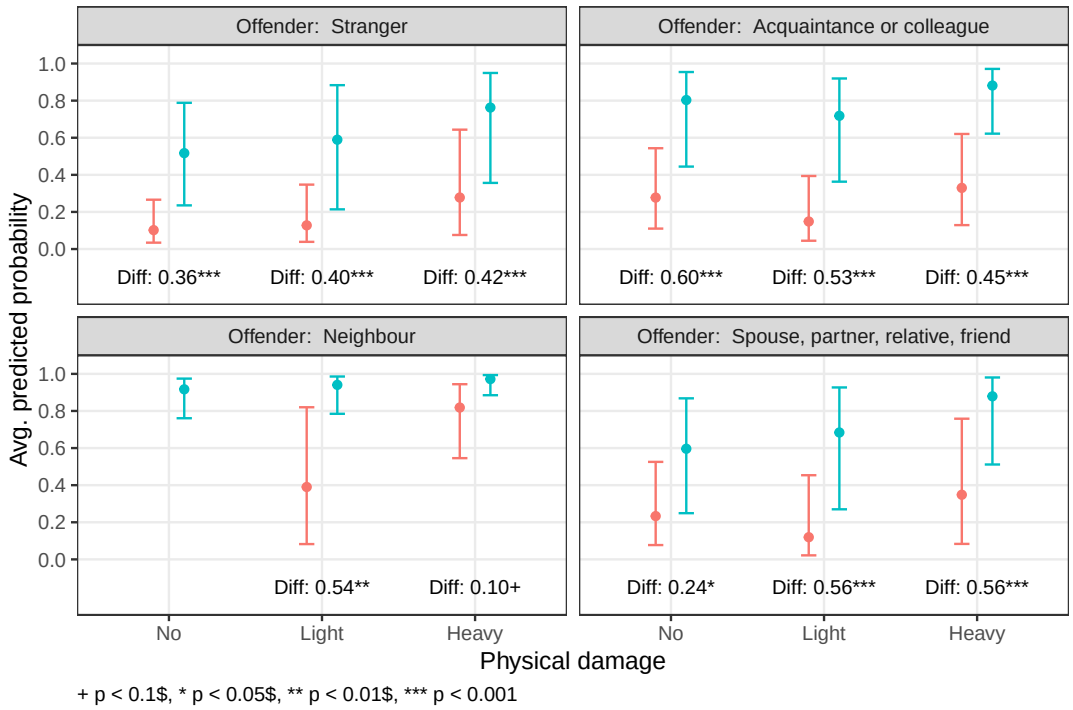


Figure 2. Predictions from model

6. Discussion

I do not observe victim-advisor and offender-advisor relationship (Knoth & Ruback, 2019), but if anything this should make my estimation more conservative.

Organizational context (Collins, Cox, & Langan, 1987; Garofalo, Siegel, & Laub, 1987; Goudriaan et al., 2004)

Knoth and Ruback (2019) *Crimes are least likely to be reported if the offender is part of the same triad as the victim and the advisor, and crimes are most likely to be reported if the victim, the advisor, and the offender are all strangers. Study 1 also found that males are more likely to protect friends who are offenders (by advising against reporting), while females are more likely to protect friends who are victims (by advising them to report). Study 2 found that the effect of these relationships on reporting is conditioned by the nature of the organization to which the offender belongs, such that males are particularly likely to protect their friends in athletic organizations and fraternities when accused of minor property crimes. Both studies found that gender differences in the advice to report are moderated by characteristics of the crime and triad structure.*

I would go as far as to suggest that in different kinds of victimization different models of reporting behavior are relevant. The cost-benefit calculus model coming from microeconomics

Scarcity of research on connection between seeking informal help and reporting may in part be due to there are seemingly no immediate policy implications (Greenberg & Ruback, 1992). However, 1) it may be more effective to work through situational advisors (victim decision making being compromised by shock), i.e. potentially anyone; 2) if we believe that consulting others heightens probability of reporting we must

conclude that lonely people report less, which gives us an insight on the direction of bias introduced by under-reporting crime.

Pescosolido (1992) 1) victimization is a shock to the whole network, 2) by including consultation with friends/family we tap into network focused research but are still far from it, 3) we can guess about structure of network but we don't know anything about content – if anything, this makes my estimation conservative.

Pescosolido (1992): *illness triggers a dynamic, social process of coping. It is through contact with others that individuals deal with situations of medical uncertainty and find ways to solve emotional and physical problems (Kulka, Veroff, and Douvan 1979). Individuals in social networks are more than an influence on help seeking, they are caregivers and advisors, part of a "therapy managing group" (Janzen 1978).*

Goudriaan et al. (2004): *According to Gartner and Macmillan (1995), however, the unpredicted finding might be in part due to measurement error in the ICVS. Contact crimes by intimates or acquaintances are less likely to be mentioned in victimization surveys than similar crimes by unknown offenders because such surveys often do not encourage respondents to think about intimate violence as relevant for the survey (Cantor & Lynch, 2000; Kalish, 1974). Victims of intimate violence tend to mention only the more serious crimes that they have also reported to the police. Put another way, victims of less serious attacks appear more willing to reveal these in surveys if the offender was a stranger. This tendency will bias estimates of the effects of victimoffender relationship on reporting to the police (Gartner & Macmillan, 1995).*

7. Conclusion

References

Anderson, E. (1999). *Code of the street.* New York: Norton.

Baert, S., De Buyser, S., Van Belle, S., Gemmel, P., Rousseau, C., Roelens, K., & Keygnaert, I. (2024). Factors related to police reporting in sexual assault care centers: are we underestimating the role of support persons? *Violence against women*, *30*(15-16), 3943–3969.

Baumer, E. P. (2002). Neighborhood disadvantage and police notification by victims of violence. *Criminology*, *40*(3), 579–616.

Berg, M. T., & Rogers, E. M. (2017). The mobilization of criminal law. *Annual Review of Law and Social Science*, *13*(1), 451–469.

Bergemann, P. (2024). How social influence affects reporting: Toward an integration of crime reporting, whistleblowing, and denunciation. *Annual Review of Sociology*, *50*.

Black, D. (1976). *The behavior of law.*

Black, D. (1979). Common sense in the sociology of law. *American Sociological Review*, 18–27.

Black, D. J. (1973). The mobilization of law. *The journal of legal studies*, *2*(1), 125–149.

Bronfenbrenner, U. (1979). *The ecology of human development: Experiments by nature and design.* Harvard university press.

Collins, J. J., Cox, B. G., & Langan, P. A. (1987). Job activities and personal crime victimization: Implications for theory. *Social Science Research*, *16*(4), 345–360.

Dzmitryieva, A., & Titaev, K. (2025). Crime reporting in russia: testing theoretical perspectives with national survey data. *International Journal of Comparative and Applied Criminal Justice*, 1–25.

Felson, R. B., Messner, S. F., & Hoskin, A. (1999). The victim-offender relationship and calling the police in assaults. *Criminology*, *37*(4), 931–948.

Felstiner, W. L., Abel, R. L., & Sarat, A. (1981). The emergence and transformation of disputes: Naming, blaming, claiming. . . .

Garofalo, J., Siegel, L., & Laub, J. (1987). School-related victimizations among adolescents: An analysis of national crime survey (ncs) narratives. *Journal of quantitative criminology*, *3*(4), 321–338.

Gottfredson, M. R., & Gottfredson, D. M. (1987). *Decision making in criminal justice: Toward the rational exercise of discretion* (Vol. 3). Springer Science & Business Media.

Gottfredson, M. R., & Hindelang, M. J. (1979a). A study of the behavior of law. *American sociological review*, 3–18.

Gottfredson, M. R., & Hindelang, M. J. (1979b). Theory and research in the sociology of law. *American Sociological Review*, 27–37.

Goudriaan, H., Lynch, J. P., & Nieuwbeerta, P. (2004). Reporting to the police in western nations: A theoretical analysis of the effects of social context. *Justice quarterly*, *21*(4), 933–969.

Goudriaan, H., Wittebrood, K., & Nieuwbeerta, P. (2006). Neighbourhood characteristics and reporting crime: Effects of social cohesion, confidence in police effectiveness and socio-economic disadvantage 1. *British journal of criminology*, *46*(4), 719–742.

Greenberg, M. S., & Beach, S. R. (2004). Property crime victims' decision to notify the police: Social, cognitive, and affective determinants. *Law and Human Behavior*, *28*(2), 177–186.

Greenberg, M. S., & Ruback, R. B. (1992). *After the crime: Victim decision making* (Vol. 9). Springer Science & Business Media.

Janoff-Bulman, R. (1986). The aftermath of victimization: Rebuilding shattered assumptions. In *Trauma and its wake.*

Kaukinen, C. (2002). The help-seeking decisions of violent crime victims: An examination of the direct and conditional effects of gender and the victim-offender relationship. *Journal of interpersonal violence*, *17*(4), 432–456.

Knoth, L. K., & Ruback, R. B. (2019). Reporting crimes to the police depends on relationship networks: Effects of ties among victims, advisors, and offenders. *Journal of interpersonal violence*, *34*(13), 2749–2773.

Mason, K. A., & Benson, M. L. (1996). The effect of social support on fraud victims' reporting behavior: A research note. *Justice Quarterly*, *13*(3), 511–524.

Orcutt, J. D., & Faison, R. (1988). Sex-role attitude change and reporting of rape victimization, 1973–1985. *The Sociological Quarterly*, *29*(4), 589–604.

Pescosolido, B. A. (1992). Beyond rational choice: The social dynamics of how people seek help. *American journal of sociology*, *97*(4), 1096–1138.

Ruback, R. B. (1993). Comment on bachman (1993) the victim-offender relationship does affect victims' decisions to report sexual assaults. *Criminal Justice and Behavior*, *20*(3), 271–279.

Ruback, R. B., Greenberg, M. S., & Westcott, D. R. (1984). Social influence and crime-victim decision making. *Journal of social issues*, *40*(1), 51–76.

Ruback, R. B., & Thompson, M. P. (2001). *Social and psychological consequences of violent victimization.* Sage.

Skogan, W. G. (1976). Citizen reporting of crime some national panel data. *Criminology*, *13*(4), 535–549.

Skogan, W. G. (1984). Reporting crimes to the police: The status of world research. *Journal of research in crime and delinquency*, *21*(2), 113–137.

Spelman, W., & Brown, D. K. (1985). *Calling the police: Citizen reporting of serious crime, 1979.* Inter-university Consortium for Political and Social Research.

Tarling, R., & Morris, K. (2010). Reporting crime to the police. *The British Journal of Criminology*, *50*(3), 474–490.

Van Kirk, M. (1978). Response time analysis. *Executive Summary). Washington, DC: US Government Printing Office.*

Wikström, P.-O. H. (2011). Does everything matter?: addressing the problem of causation and explanation in the study of crime. In *When crime appears* (pp. 53–72). Routledge.

Xie, M., & Baumer, E. P. (2019). Crime victims' decisions to call the police: Past research and new directions. *Annual Review of Criminology*, *2*(1), 217–240.

Zaykowski, H. (2015). Reconceptualizing victimization and victimization responses. *Crime & Delinquency*, *61*(2), 271–296.